

EXECUTIVE CASE STUDY & BENCHMARK

Villa Booking Experience & Flow Analysis

Deep Dive: EkoStay vs StayVista vs Stay Willas Luxury Villas

Prepared for: Stay Willas Operations & Tech | Focus: Conversion Rate, Payment Friction & UX

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & KEY TAKEAWAYS

In India's luxury villa rental ecosystem, booking flow architecture directly dictates conversion rate, average booking value, and guest retention. StayVista operates as an enterprise hospitality aggregator focusing on 100% upfront automated digital checkout, high customer qualification, and mandatory strict terms. In contrast, EkoStay deploys a hybrid model with partial 50% advance payments and heavy human-assisted WhatsApp sales intervention to lower upfront commitment barriers. Stay Willas has the unique opportunity to combine the instantaneous zero-friction speed of StayVista with the high-trust flexible deposit model of EkoStay.

2. EKOSTAY: ARCHITECTURE, FLOW & TACTICS

EkoStay (founded 2018) manages 300+ holiday homes across 20+ destinations (Lonavala, Alibaug, Goa, Panchgani). Their digital funnel prioritizes lead acquisition and sales-assisted closing over pure self-serve checkout.

Step 1: Search & Filter

Location selector, check-in/out date picker, and guest count. Displays instant price per night.

Step 2: Property Page & Lead Interception

Users view amenities, pool photos, house rules. Prominent floating WhatsApp button ("Chat with Stay Expert") intercepts hesitancy.

Step 3: Booking Options Provided

Two primary checkout paths: (A) "Book Now" via Airpay gateway, OR (B) "Inquire Now / Send Enquiry" which routes directly to CRM for agent callback.

Step 4: Flexible Split-Payment Model

Guests can pay 50% advance token online to lock the dates, with the remaining 50% payable at check-in or 7 days prior. Drastically reduces booking drop-off.

Step 5: Meals & Security Deposit

Meals are NOT bundled automatically. Semi-equipped kitchens; meals charged separately per house.

EkoStay Strengths

- 50% advance option yields higher initial impulse conversion.
- WhatsApp concierge closes custom requirements & large groups.
- Clear upfront breakdown of refundable security deposit.

EkoStay Friction Points

- Manual offline balance collection causes check-in friction.
- High dependency on manual sales agents; delays at night.
- Inconsistent instant confirmation on certain unmanaged villas.

3. STAYVISTA: ARCHITECTURE, FLOW & TACTICS

StayVista (formerly Vista Rooms, backed by DSG & Singularity) manages 500+ luxury estates. Positioned as high-end luxury hospitality, their booking flow is institutional, strictly gated, and optimized for maximum Average Order Value (AOV).

Step 1: Hyper-Curated Discovery
Filtering by occasions (Family getaway, Corporate, Celebrations), curated collections, and destination amenities.

Step 2: Transparent Experience Configuration
Real-time dynamic pricing calculation, showing per-night rate, taxes (GST 18%), cleaning fee, and pre-selected meal options.

Step 3: 100% Upfront Digital Checkout
Requires 100% full payment upfront via Razorpay / Juspay (Credit Cards, EMI, UPI, Net Banking). No partial payment at check-in allowed.

Step 4: Meal Bundling & Chef Service Upsell
Guests must select either fixed Veg/Non-Veg meal packages per day or pay mandatory chef service fees. No self-cooking in premium properties.

Step 5: Automated Verification & Concierge Handover
Immediately issues automated PDF voucher and WhatsApp bot triggers mandatory digital KYC ID upload and security deposit payment before arrival.

StayVista Strengths

- 100% upfront payment guarantees 0% check-in cash collection issues.
- High trust UI with verified reviews, 360-degree virtual tours.
- Seamless digital KYC and automated WhatsApp onboarding.

StayVista Friction Points

- 100% upfront payment creates high resistance for
- Rigid cancellation policies turn away spontaneous travelers.
- Mandatory meal charges inflate the perceived baseline price.

4. DIRECT COMPARATIVE MATRIX

FEATURE / DIMENSION	EKOSTAY	STAYVISTA	STAY WILLAS (OUR STRATEGY)
Primary Booking Mode	Hybrid (Instant + WhatsApp)	Pure Instant Online Checkout	Dual: 1-Click Instant + Direct Concierge
Advance Payment Required	50% Advance online	100% Full Payment upfront	Flexible: 25% Token or 100% Full Pay
Balance Payment	At check-in / 7 days before	N/A (Collected upfront)	At Check-in (UPI/Cash/Card)
Payment Gateways	Airpay, UPI, Bank Transfer	Razorpay, Juspay, EMI, Cards	Direct UPI, Federal Bank, Razorpay
Direct Property Selector	No (Search by City first)	No (Location/Theme search)	YES (Instant 1-click on Homepage)
Meal Handling	A la carte / Kitchen fee	Fixed mandatory meal package	Transparent packages or private kitchen
Security Deposit	15k - 115k at check-in	Pre-collected digitally	Instant UPI Hold / On-arrival deposit

5. ACTIONABLE STRATEGY & BLUEPRINT FOR STAY WILLAS

Based on benchmark findings, Stay Willas should avoid both StayVista's high payment barrier (100% full upfront) and EkoStay's heavy manual friction (delayed WhatsApp responses). Below are the 4 optimized booking workflows designed specifically for Stay Willas properties (The Angle House, Canopy Crest, Casa De Reva, and Willow Peak: Breeze, Crest, Heaven).

Workflow Option 1: Instant Direct Property Booking (Live on Homepage)

FASTEST (0 FRICTION)

Users choose property directly from Homepage Dropdown ("The Angle House", "Willow Peak Breeze", etc.), pick dates, and immediately open the booking confirmation modal without navigating through multi-step search pages. Eliminates 2 intermediate page loads.

Workflow Option 2: The "Split-Pay" Advantage (Beat StayVista)

MAX CONVERSION

Allow guests to reserve luxury villas with a 25% or 50% advance token via instant UPI or card. The remaining balance is payable at check-in. This removes high-ticket hesitation for bookings above ₹25,000 while maintaining a competitive rate.

Workflow Option 3: VIP Concierge & WhatsApp Fast-Track (Beat EkoStay)

HIGH AOV & EVENTS

For corporate offsites, weddings, and celebrations requiring customized catering or 20+ guests, one-click WhatsApp routing pre-fills property name, guest count, and dates into the chat for an immediate quote within 90 seconds.

Workflow Option 4: Zero-Fee Bank Transfer & Corporate Invoicing

0% PAYMENT GATEWAY FEE

Direct RTGS / NEFT / IMPS transfer directly to the verified Federal Bank account (Sushant Girish Chandra Tiwari, A/C: 99980100571517, IFSC: FDRL0001542). Saves the business 2% to 3% gateway MDR commission on high-value bookings.

INTEGRATION QUERY: CAN PAYMENT GATEWAYS WORK ON A REGULAR/SAVINGS ACCOUNT?

YES. Razorpay, Cashfree, and Instamojo allow Individual / Sole Proprietor onboarding without a registered Private Limited company or Current Bank Account.

- Setup: Choose 'Unregistered Business / Individual' or 'Freelancer/Proprietor' during KYC.
- Bank Link: Connect the Federal Bank account (Sushant Tiwari) with PAN, Aadhaar, and cancelled cheque.
- Monthly Limits: ₹50,000/month initially until video/document KYC completion, then upgraded to unlimited.
- Alternative Zero-MDR Solution: Deploy Direct UPI QR (PhonePe / GPay Business) linked to Sushant's Federal Bank account (VPA: sushant650@federal) for instant 0% fee settlement.

STAY WILLAS LUXURY HOSPITALITY GROUP

Properties: The Angle House | Canopy Crest | Casa De Reva | Willow Peak (Breeze, Crest, Heaven)

Account: Federal Bank | Sushant Girish Chandra Tiwari | A/C: 99980100571517 | IFSC: FDRL0001542

STATUS: READY FOR PRODUCTION DEPLOYMENT